

The Psychological School

Høffding's Introduction to Treschow

in *Selected Passages from Danish Philosophical Literature*

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Translated from the Danish by Hans Halvorson

Monuments of Denmark's National Literature, III.

Copenhagen: Gyldendal, 1910

IV

THE PSYCHOLOGICAL SCHOOL (TRESCHOW, SIBBERN, HOWITZ).

1. That interest in experience, and in the problems that arise on the ground of experience, by which Holberg and Sneedorff had been animated, found voice again in a series of men who in the nineteenth century cultivated psychology and sought partly to bring it into close connection with natural science, partly to treat wider philosophical questions from the standpoint of experience. The first in the series is NIELS TRESCHOW (1751–1833), author of the first independent Danish psychology. In his philosophy he maintained—in opposition to German philosophy's absorption into general and abstract concepts—the individual and the concrete as what is properly real (“Is there any concept or any idea of singular things?” *Videnskabernes Selskabs Skrifter* 1807); and it was therefore natural for him to suppose that the differences between species had developed historically and successively. The “moral” misgivings about this supposition he has refuted in a fine manner (*Elementer til Historiens Filosofi* 1811).

A. THE INEXHAUSTIBILITY OF THE INDIVIDUAL

B. THE DOCTRINE OF DEVELOPMENT

We gladly see the singular appearances that occur in experience explained in some natural way. Our desire for knowledge is thereby satisfied, whereas it is rebuffed or thrust back when omnipotence or some other supernatural cause is put forward. In the childhood of reason one does not know the distinction between the natural and the supernatural: the two mingle in the less cultivated person's manner of representation, and are the same. It is perhaps less a real error than an idea not distinctly thought. But however that may be, therein lies the whole reason why the ancients, in all cases usual and unusual alike, turned their thoughts to the influence of a god or of a hidden power; whereas we always believe that the nearest causes must be found in something visible and known, and regard only the higher causes as concealed and supersensible.

As concerns the first origin of the world, of animals and of plants, we are therefore inclined to assume an inconceivable creation, although we grant that in their subsequent changes and propagation nature's own forces, according to laws once determined, are chiefly at work. If one carries the merely physical investigations somewhat further, one does seem to become aware of a kind of possibility of seeing how the so-called lifeless materials and bodies may have formed themselves by an innate force; but one despairs of grasping the production of organic bodies in the same way. From this arises the evolution-system, adopted until the most recent times with almost universal approval, whose ultimate ground is the many kinds of shoots or germs that seemed able to have received existence only by an immediate creation. That these could have been produced by a raw matter's gradually self-developing force—this opinion seemed to most as unreasonable as it was dangerous and bordering on explicit denial of God. How deeply, it was further thought, is human nature thereby degraded, indeed every living being—although the ancients did not find it degrading, but reverently worshipped the earth as their mother. Yet we see that such is nature's course. Of omnipotence one forms the conception that it can bring forth everything at once, the greatest along with the least. One wonders, therefore, and rightly, on learning that everything comes to be out of something preceding which, when we consider the whole, is always, as far as form goes, inferior to what follows. The seed or germ, even of human beings and animals, is in the beginning nothing but a wholly formless fluid: if we pursue it to its origin—with our thoughts, when the eye can no longer do so—then it loses itself at last in materials that we cannot distinguish from the common ones. But how little are these known to us! How glorious is that dust which we use as an emblem of lowliness and out of ignorance

despise! Is the common matter anything other than the visible God, than a revelation of the highest being itself?¹ Just as the Ideas develop out of his infinite understanding by an eternal birth, so the seed, the fundamental forms of all things, lies enveloped in matter's womb, and only in time, and consequently only gradually, becomes intuitable images of those patterns which they ever more nearly strive to express.

The first human beings did not arise immediately either from the sea or from the earth. Yet in both lies the mediate ground of both our matter and our form. Of the earth we are formed. For before the solid separated itself from the fluid, nothing living yet existed, least of all the most excellent creature among all living things. Nature's forces are not different from the Godhead's own force, except insofar as the latter considered in itself is infinite, while in the former it reveals itself in a finite manner, and in its infinity only as an unceasingly increasing magnitude. In this sense one may say that matter has formed itself, advancing gradually from the less perfect to the most perfect human form. One may likewise say with truth that God, after having brought forth matter itself—or, by its properties, having made his own being as intuitable as it could become—has out of it again brought forth all things. These turns of speech, which most hold to be as different as heaven and earth, mean at bottom the same, and indicate only two human manners of representation.

In a still more mediate way water is the origin of all things. The ancients, who out of an easily excusable impatience leapt past the nearest and intermediate causes in order to soar up to the highest, misunderstood these propositions about our origin, which are in themselves quite correct. Either they let human beings and gods arise immediately out of chaos, which is the original fluid; or else they held that by the united forces of the sun, the air, the water and the earth, the most perfect animals and human beings themselves were begotten of the last, just as mold and maggots are of putrefied bodies. The first opinion rested on a mythical tradition and a poetic presentation of it. The poet's imagination resembles the chaos they sing of, and in the same way contains the seed of reason's most glorious works. It comprehends the whole at a glance, but does not notice that what in this flash of genius—as in the divine understanding—exists all at once, can become actual for the senses only gradually. The second hypothesis is indeed a fruit of experience and reflection, but an unripe one. For although the newest experiences seem in this to agree with the most ancient—that some among the lowest plant and animal species can come forth in this way without the usual propagation from their like, indeed even wholly new ones that did not exist before—we have nevertheless not

¹By matter one must here understand not the phenomenon, which is an object of experience, but its supersensible substrate, the ultimate subject of the same, its eternal essence itself.

the least ground, from nature's regular course, to suppose the same of the larger and more developed organisms in the two kingdoms of living things. Such giant strides, as a sudden transition from the lowest to the highest degree of development, are no less at variance with philosophy's fundamental principles than with experience and analogy. For from the concept of time and finitude the opposite manifestly follows. How was any time possible without order and a continuous advance in which there can be no leap? How can one think the infinite being expressed in finite forms except by an eternal approximation to the former; or conceive time as eternity's image, unless it is unbroken and uniform throughout?

From materials that seem raw, because one becomes aware of no form in them there occurs, then, an imperceptible transition to more determinate shapes, whose regular sequence or series one can for that reason only indicate in general, as I have also done above. To separate them by sharply marked boundaries will therefore not do, because nature's course, in those deviations or degenerations by which the former genera and species are transformed into wholly new ones, is not merely creeping, but so slow withal that neither our own experience nor history's far too small compass puts us in a position to follow its almost imperceptible traces. After the lapse of millennia, the least ambiguous remains of animals and human beings—which may be regarded as ancestors of those now existing, though rather different—still give occasion for objections and doubts. I shall therefore adduce none here. One will find them described in abundance in the writings of naturalists, but most of them uncertain, all of them disputed. What may be right or wrong with respect to these one cannot, as everyone sees, decide *a priori*; but the matter itself, which one would prove from them, is nevertheless not doubtful.

An immediate creation, whether of actual animals and plants or of their nearest germs, is empty words. If, on the other hand, the question is of a mediate or natural production, then no other is possible than the one adduced. The human race has consequently not existed from the beginning in its present form and shape, although every history, the sacred as well as the secular, must naturally proceed from this point. The specific criteria by which natural history now distinguishes this being from others, it has not always had, but has taken on gradually. I venture boldly to advance this opinion, not as a mere hypothesis, but as an undeniable consequence of an order of nature that is not accidental but necessary, whose series one cannot break off without absurdity and contradiction. It would, on the other hand, be temerity if I were to maintain that one can with the same certainty depict the human shape in every preceding condition, or determine to which species of creatures now known we formerly belonged, or from which we have

perhaps sprung. I am convinced that the human being constitutes a species or genus for itself, and by no means believe that the ape—as the Tibetans, according to *Pallas's* report, maintain—or any other animal, however high they may rise through all eternity, will ever become human, or just the same as, even if more than, what we now are. But I am indeed of the opinion that our first ancestors, whose memory no history and no archive can have preserved, ran through a course of life in which neither could the higher gifts of mind come to that maturity which they reach in the beautiful and fully developed body we now bear, nor was mere sensibility provided with all the requisite instruments for so many kinds of sensations, so fine and so vivid. Nature's manifoldness, the inexhaustible wealth of Ideas in the Godhead's bosom, their destination to an eternal and ever-progressing actuality, does not permit us the thought that all beings are nothing but the same thing at different degrees of the height they must ascend. What, then, does the inequality among creatures of one species mean, which despite this individual difference can each in its own way be equally perfect? Why should such manifoldness not have place among species as well?

Have we perhaps reason to be ashamed of such an origin? This question can be answered quite briefly. We need not go so far back in time to find stronger grounds for our humiliation. How many years is it since each of us stood far below the life of the animals, indeed of the meanest plant? Is it not more important to think of what we now are, and shall one day quite certainly become, than of what we were—as if the proud *cedar* would look down with scorn upon the young shoot that springs up at its roots, or we upon the fetus whose heart has scarcely begun to beat in the mother's womb. Everywhere all that lives has the same root: divine is our descent, eternal and infinite our destiny.
